

protect your documents, presentations and spreadsheets. This way, even if someone gains access to your computer, your personal files cannot be opened easily. If your password is strong enough, it would take at least a year for today's most powerful computer to break it.

How To Choose A Good Password

This section applies to any password(s) used anywhere, Linux or otherwise. Firstly, don't have a password that your friends or even acquaintances can guess. That leaves out your own name, your dog's name, the name of your city, etc. Use something uncommon and something only you can think of, or know how the password is arrived at. A common approach is to use a sentence that you can remember well (but not others!) and take the first letter from every word and make the password.

There are password cracking software for files created for Microsoft Office, Winzip, etc. They use a brute force method by which all possible combinations of characters are tested on the file to see if it matches the set password. Obviously, more the number of characters and the types of characters, the more difficult it becomes for the cracking software to crack the password.

- m Avoid using English (dictionary words)
- m Use many characters in your password.
- m Use numbers randomly in the password.
- m Capital letters (upper case) can be used in part.
- m Special characters such as '@' '\$' '^' may also be used if the software permits it.

This more or less covers the basics of what you need to know about securing your PC from attackers who may get physical access. Of course, the best way to secure it is to prevent physical access if at all possible.

In the next section we will see how you can prevent unauthorised access to your PC through the internet. We shall briefly look at firewalls and IP filtering.